It's a Global Issue: AI, Digital Transformation, and Governance - Mapping the Landscape for the Future of the Higher Education Communities

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Abstract

The development of AI, at an above benchmark pace, has become a worldwide worrying issue and a central narrative in the tertiary level learning institutions. Digital transformation, on the other hand, is updating the educational systems, which necessitates effective governance to steer these improvements. This paper provides an integrated overview of these three pillars "AI, digital transformation, and governance" and explores their interplay in reshaping the landscape of higher education. Drawing on key insights from the EUNIS 2024 conference and recent global studies, the paper examines AI's transformative potential in optimizing learning and administration, the role of digital transformation in enabling scalable and innovative educational services, and the urgent need for governance frameworks to ensure ethical, equitable, and sustainable practices. The analysis highlights current gaps such as the lagging development of regulatory frameworks amid rapid tech progress, and it sheds light on emerging needs, barriers, and innovations (including the use of AI and XR

in teaching and learning, strategies for digital readiness, and models for ethical leadership). Of particular interest is the argument provided AI, digital transformation, and governance, which justifies the need for a Global Compact on AI in education that would foster international collaboration and standards. This all-encompassing tracking and mapping of trends, challenges, and opportunities provides higher education institutions a blueprint for strategic decision making concerning technological integration and serves as a guide for policy makers in the reformation of higher learning education.